

Your 3 A.M. Protocol Card

The complete tool from Your 3 A.M. Wake-Up Is a Cortisol Problem — Fix It by Simon Gebhart.

This card works on its own. If you skipped straight here, everything you need is on this page.

Part 1: The 3 A.M. Decision Tree

Use this the moment you wake in the night.

Step 1 — First 20 minutes: Stay in bed and shuffle.

Don't check the clock. Don't calculate how much sleep you have left. Start cognitive shuffling: pick a random word, picture it clearly, then jump to an unrelated word and picture that. A hat. A red bridge. A dog on a beach. A candle. Keep jumping. There's no story, no sequence. This interrupts the anxiety loop without engaging it. The technique is based on early-stage research — results haven't yet been published in peer-reviewed form — but the theoretical rationale is sound and the cost of trying it is zero.

If you drift back to sleep during this 20-minute window: good. Stay there.

Step 2 — After 20 minutes awake: Get out of bed.

If you've been awake and alert for roughly 20 minutes and sleep is clearly not coming, get up. Don't fight it. Getting out of bed is not failure — lying awake in bed for two hours is the thing that makes tomorrow night worse.

Go to your exit kit location.

Step 3 — Out of bed: Dim, quiet, no screens.

- Lamp only — dim and warm. No overhead lights.
- No phone, no TV, no tablet.
- Read a paperback, do a low-key puzzle, sit quietly. Nothing requiring decisions or generating emotion.
- Your sleep pressure is rebuilding while you do this. Let it build.

Step 4 — Return to bed only when sleepy.

Not tired. Not bored. Not "it's been long enough." Genuinely sleepy — heavy eyelids, thoughts starting to drift and fragment. That's the cue. Return to bed and do not check the clock.

The clock rule: Your clock stays covered or turned away all night. Your alarm is set. You do not need to know what time it is until the alarm sounds. Every time you check the clock, you feed the arousal loop.

Part 2: The Sleep Window Calculator

This is the ongoing protocol — what you do every day, not just at 3 a.m.

The Lancet HABIT trial (642 participants, 35 practices) found that sleep restriction therapy reduced insomnia severity significantly more than sleep hygiene alone at 6 months (Cohen's $d = -0.74$). A network meta-analysis of 80 trials (15,351 participants) confirmed sleep restriction and stimulus control are the two most effective components of CBT-I. This protocol runs both.

Step 1 — Find your average actual sleep hours.

For at least three nights, track the time you fell asleep and the time you finally stopped trying to sleep after your 3 a.m. wake. Add up total sleep (not time in bed). Divide by the number of nights.

Example: fell asleep at 10:30, woke at 3:15, fell back asleep briefly, gave up at 5:00. Actual sleep approximately 5.5 hours.

Step 2 — Calculate your sleep window.

Average actual sleep hours + 30 minutes = your prescribed window

Example: 5.5 hours + 0.5 hours = **6 hours**

Step 3 — Set your fixed wake time.

Pick a time you can hold every day, including weekends. Your circadian anchor depends on this consistency. Write it here:

My fixed wake time: _____ (example: 6:30 a.m.)

Step 4 — Calculate your new (later) target bedtime.

Count backwards from your fixed wake time by the length of your prescribed window.

Fixed wake time minus sleep window = target bedtime

Example: 6:30 a.m. minus 6 hours = **12:30 a.m.**

My sleep window: _____ hours

My fixed wake time: _____

My new target bedtime: _____

Do not go to bed before this time. Even if you're tired. Even if it's 11 p.m. and you're falling asleep on the sofa. Get up, stay active, hold the window.

Step 5 — The 4-week consolidation arc.

- **Week 1-2:** Hold the window exactly. Sleep will often feel worse before it improves as sleep pressure builds. This is expected. Measure sleep efficiency (see below), not how refreshed you feel.

- **Week 3–4:** If your sleep efficiency is above 85% for five or more nights in a row, move your target bedtime 15 minutes earlier. Repeat this adjustment every two weeks if efficiency stays above 85%.
- **Check-in date (fill this in):** _____ (14 days from today)

Sleep efficiency formula:

$$(\text{Hours actually asleep} \div \text{Hours in bed}) \times 100$$

Example: 5.5 hours asleep ÷ 6 hours in bed × 100 = **91.7% efficiency**

This number matters more than total hours in the first weeks. You're consolidating sleep, not extending it yet. Extension comes after consolidation.

The stimulus control rules (run these alongside the window):

1. Bed is for sleep only. No reading in bed, no phone in bed, no TV in bed.
2. If you wake and are awake for more than 20 minutes: use the Decision Tree above.
3. No naps during the consolidation period. Naps bleed the sleep pressure the window is building.

Fill in your card now:

Field	Your Number
Average actual sleep hours	
Sleep window (+ 30 min)	
Fixed wake time	
New target bedtime	
4-week check-in date	

Do this now: Fill in the Protocol Card above. Write your sleep window start time, your fixed wake time, and your 4-week check-in date in each row. Put this page on your nightstand or photograph it with your phone. This is your complete protocol.

More printable cards like this, free: [Simon Gebhart's Field Notes](#)

The full guide: [amazon.com/dp/B0GX32JXVY](https://www.amazon.com/dp/B0GX32JXVY)